

**Fostering Team**

Civic Offices, Euclid Street,  
Swindon, SN1 2JH

**Tel:** 01793 465700

**Email:** [fosteringbst@swindon.gov.uk](mailto:fosteringbst@swindon.gov.uk)

**Private and Confidential**

Mr Oliver Yerbury-Hodgson  
[oyerburyhodgson@gmail.com](mailto:oyerburyhodgson@gmail.com)

**Please ask for:** Sam Hicks

**Direct Dial No:** 01793 465700

**Email:** [fosteringbst@swindon.gov.uk](mailto:fosteringbst@swindon.gov.uk)

**Date:** 08/12/2025

**Swindon Borough Council - Adult Child Reference**

Dear Mr Yerbury-Hodgson

**Re:** Mark and Monica Yerbury-Hodgson

Your parent(s), carer or family member provided your name as a personal reference as part of an application to become a foster carer for Swindon. We consider personal references to be a critical part of the assessment, the benefit of your relationship with the applicant(s) can help us understand their strengths as parents as well as areas of concern.

Please respond honestly.

Your information is important to us for several reasons:

- We need to determine if the applicants known to you, will be successful foster parents. When a child is placed in to a foster home, s/he needs security, affection, good physical care, education and nurturing. The foster family must have the ability to handle stress constructively, work as part of a team, advocate for the child's needs, use non-physical discipline and make a commitment to the child.
- We need help getting to know the family better. Tell us about their strengths and limitations related to their potential as foster parents. Should you need additional space, feel free to attach more pages or use the back of the form.

Please find enclosed a copy of the consent form provided by the applicant.

Thank you for your assistance in this matter.

Yours sincerely

**Sam Hicks**



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**Business Support Administrator  
Fostering Team**

**NAME OF APPLICANT**

Mark and Monica Yerbury-Hodgson

**PERSON COMPLETING THE REFERENCE**

**Name** Oliver Yerbury-Hodgson

**Email** oyerburyhodgson@gmail.com

**Telephone** 07910887587

*(Note: If there are two applicants, please comment on each applicant separately.  
If a question does not apply to the applicant, please write "N/A".)*

**How are you related to each applicant? (Example: biological child, stepchild, grandchild, other)**

Biological child of Mark Yerbury-Hodgson and Monica Yerbury-Hodgson

**Are you aware of the plan to foster? What is your understanding of fostering?**

I am aware of the plan to foster. As far as I understand so far, fostering is generally done during an interim period to care for a child if/until adoption. I also understand that fostering can sometimes happen over several years.

Additionally, it's my understanding that through fostering, there's generally more support and oversight from the council.

**How would you describe being parented by the applicant(s)? What did you like? What did you dislike?**

Growing up, my parents would ensure that I had the means and resources to develop friendships, have hobbies, eat well, succeed in my studies and have a secure environment. They enforced some healthy boundaries such as limiting screen time, setting expectations about responsibilities such as coming home at a reasonable time, and establishing some earned pocket money.

I liked that my parents created a safe space for me to talk honestly with them and not feel judged. In return for building up trust with my parents, they'd also allowed me freedoms which I believe helped me shape my character early on.

Being the youngest in my family, my parents likely sheltered me from the difficulties they had raising my sister. I'm generally thankful that they did so, as it meant I could largely not be involved in conflict unnecessarily, but I dislike that I now don't truly understand her past.

In general, my parents were fair and ultimately prepared me incredibly well for adult life.

**What is your relationship with the applicant(s) now?**

I'm still very close with my parents. We're better now than we were in the past at having difficult conversations. From experience, we've realised that a culture of being quiet and not addressing the elephant in the room rarely has a good outcome. We've learnt that clear and early communication, even if it's bad, is ultimately the best way to handle things.

I'd normally visit my parents once every 1-2 months and call them once a week. I still feel like I could rely on my parents to look after me if I was ever truly in need. I'd therefore consider them a part of my support network and expect to be a part of theirs.

**What do you believe are each of the applicants Strengths and Limitations?**

**Mark's Strengths**

- Reliable and organised
- Even when emotions are high amongst our family, this doesn't stop him from fulfilling his responsibilities
- Committed to help those around him
- A very happy, forthcoming, and welcoming person

**Mark's Weaknesses**

- Communication during confrontation can sometimes be a challenge for my Dad
- Possibly not speaking up when his feelings have been hurt, opting instead to remain stoic

**Monica's Strengths**

- A very strong maternal instinct. Even though me and my sister are in our 30s, my Mother still wants to look after us
- High emotional intelligence
- Incredibly caring and insightful
- Establishes boundaries early

**Monica's Weaknesses**

- Expresses emotions in more extremes than me and my Dad (strength and weakness), meaning that she more regularly feels sad, angry, ecstatic

**How would you describe the applicants relationship? -Their Support Network and their Ability to work in Partnership**

My parents' relationship with each other is:

- Committed - They've been faced with adversity on a regular basis during my lifetime and have continued to stay together. This includes pressure from family members, their Parent's staying with them, my sister's continued dependence on them
- Loving - My parents enjoy each others presence, and want to spend time together
- Regulated - If there are disagreements, they appear to have techniques to regulate this. Including leaving space for each other, apologising, etc.
- If they experience marital issues, this usually consists of arguments about the practicalities of running a household, and haven't extended to more significant marital issues to my knowledge. They have sought help and worked through these if/when they've come up

Their support network consists of:

Mark

- My Dad's Sister
- Oliver (Me)
- Old work colleagues whom he regularly meets up with
- My childhood friends' parents
- Neighbours
- Loki's paternal grandmother

Monica

- Network of friends from the past 20-30 years
- Childhood friends
- My childhood friends' parents
- Neighbours
- Loki's paternal grandmother

Their ability to work in partnership has improved significantly as they communicate honestly and early with each other, and largely share responsibilities when they've cared for others.

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**Is there anything from your own childhood and upbringing that would be relevant to know in relation to the applicant's ability to care for children?**

My parents never raised their voice or argued with me growing up. I know that this is largely because, relatively speaking, I was an easy child to raise.

My parents didn't shy away from opportunities for me and my sister to have friends around.

**How do you feel about the applicants becoming foster carers?**

I'm incredibly thankful that my parents are volunteering to become foster carers of Loki. I understand that it won't be an easy journey, and I'm prepared to help in whatever capacity I can, but I truly believe they're committed to giving Loki the best possible future.

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**Would a child living in the applicant(s) care be safe? Do you know of any reason why the applicant(s) should not be approved as a foster carer(s)?**

Yes, a child living in my parents' care would be safe. I have no reason why my parents should not be approved as foster carers.



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**Please provide any other information that you think is relevant:**

If the fostering process can offer any guardrails or guidance around Loki's contact with Loki's mother (and father), I think that would really benefit my parents. My parents are occasionally a part of my sister's support network, and we'd all like that to be fairly balanced with Loki's needs.

**Please tick one of the following boxes to indicate your consent to sharing the information you have provided:**

**I am happy for my reference to be shared with the applicant.**



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|------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Signature</b> |  |
| <b>Date</b>      | 17/12/2025                                                                        |